

STICK TO THE LAW

Laws are rules that apply to an entire country or community. They spell out what people can or cannot do within that society and lay down punishments for wrongdoers. One purpose of the law is to settle disputes between neighbors and make it easier for people to live together happily. The earliest set of laws dates back at least 4,000 years to ancient Mesopotamia (modern Iraq).

LAWLESS SOCIETY

Imagine living in a country without any laws—people would be able to do exactly what they liked. Of course, it would mean you could do anything you wanted, but although that might sound like fun, think of the dangers. You would have no protection against robbers or murderers. There would be no traffic laws and no police officers to sort out the resulting chaos. What a mess!

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

Wrongdoers found guilty of committing a crime in a court of law are sentenced to punishment by the judge, who may send them to prison for a set period of time. Imprisonment helps make things safe for others by taking lawbreakers out of the community. It also acts as a deterrent to stop would-be criminals from breaking the law.

BREAKING THE LAW

Here are some of the crime categories recognized by the law:

- **against a person:** assault, robbery, kidnapping, manslaughter, murder
- **against property:** arson, theft, burglary, vandalism, fraud, deception
- **against the state:** conspiracy, espionage, treason
- **against justice:** perversion of justice, bribery of juries, perjury

“THE TIME IS ALWAYS RIGHT TO DO WHAT IS RIGHT.”

Martin Luther King Jr. (1929–1968), American civil-rights leader